

Unravelling original thought

This has been one of the most difficult months in a long long time. But amid all the chaos, there were certain moments that stood out. One of these was at the IGX gaming event we all (Digit boys and girl) attended. There, at an innocuous but over-crowded booth, we 'encountered' an indigenously developed product and it really caught our collective attention. Dubbed 'The Tesseract', it was a VR solution not unlike the Oculus Rift. The Tesseract was developed by the most unlikely of suspects – eagle-eyed engineering dropouts – and I was pretty intrigued when they explained some of the features that made their product original. The algorithm powering their device was its USP - it promised the conversion of not just games but any (yes you read right, any) sort of digital content into 3D. How? The algorithm apparently extracts data before it gets rendered and tweaks it to apply depth perception (resizing objects in the foreground and other jiggery pokery). Humour aside, if done well, the concept has a lot of potential.

All good, right? Then what was bugging me?

With phrases such as moonshot innovation, reinventing the wheel, and many others being bandied about way too carelessly in the industry these days, I am allowed my scepticism. While I admired these college students for following their dreams, I wasn't sure if this was just another "me too" concept, but only cheaper. This, unfortunately, is something that our part of the world is notorious for. Therefore, I did a bit of research, talked to industry experts and came across concepts such as IonVR, which are similar to what the Tesseract boys (and girl) are trying to achieve especially in their endeavour to address VR sickness.

So, of course there wasn't any plagiarism here of any sort by these Absentia VR kids – because their product is sufficiently different – and it may just as easily be one of those cases of concurrent innovation. Historically too, many people in the world have worked on problems and found solutions simultaneously. The discovery of 'radio' is an often-cited example.

Still, it got me thinking about the very idea of 'original thought' – again, probably not so originally. A couple of months ago, I wrote a piece exhorting the need for technology infusion into education and governance – both were certainly not ideas that I've manufactured myself (not that I claimed to do so). I'm sure if you dig hard

enough, you'll find not just one, but maybe 10 other people propagating the same idea as far back as a decade ago (or longer).

Here's another example - say I decide to write something on undying computer myths. Covering things like the truth about safely removing hardware, HDD defragmentation, right-click refresh, and so on. Is it an idea I just thought up while writing this editorial at 12 in the night, three days past the magazine closing deadline? Or is it something that is based on a stray Lifehacker piece I probably came across three years ago? Or could it be a How-to Geek newsletter from three months ago? Can I follow these breadcrumbs to unearth the 'seminal' thought that led to these ideas? Possibly.

In one of my very early editorials, I'd talked the theme of incremental change vs. revolutionary change. More than a year later I came across a Quora answer in which I found this quote by Larry Page - "Especially in technology, we need revolutionary change, not incremental change" - as it turns out it's one of his favourite themes for speeches. Did I get "influenced" by him? Although I wrote on this theme before I read his quote, I'm not going to be cocky (or hopeful) enough to assume he is a Digit reader!

What is truly original then, if at any given moment we're a sum total of our experiences and learnings? Is any of what Apple or Google or any other company doing, truly original? Has there been any original thought in this world after Leonardo Da Vinci? Is the proverbial well of new ideas truly running dry? I better stop before I give myself a panic attack.

I'm exaggerating for effect of course (I think) – there have been many instances of original thinking throughout history – but you have to admit, they are rare. Some (if not all) of our cover stories might constitute those rare exceptions (we hope).

What do you think? Have you seen examples of truly original thought around you?



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"What is truly original then, if at any given moment we're a sum total of our experiences and learnings?"

A handwritten signature in black ink, appearing to read 'Siddharth Parwatay'.

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